

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS · A TRADE NAME OF ALPHAPLAY LLC

Owner's Manual

Everything you need to know about the business on a few calm pages: what it is, how it runs without you, the short list of things only you can do, and how to stop it. Written September 28, 2026; updated that evening for the \$500 budget and the latest counts.

The short version

1. **Nothing is live yet.** The products, listings, website and marketing are built. A safety file, `ops/PAUSE`, keeps anything from being published until you say "go".
2. **Your part is about 4½ hours of one-time setup** over the next two weeks, then roughly 10–15 minutes a week of yes/no approvals.
3. **The most urgent step takes 5 minutes:** make the GitHub repository private (step 1 in section 4).
4. **You will only hear about money.** One line a day, a short note each week and month, plus one line whenever something truly needs you.
5. **Launch budget: \$500 at most** (your decision, September 28). No ads, no paid reviewers and one domain at launch; everything else waits until sales pay for it (`business/LAUNCH-BUDGET-500.md`).
6. **Honest money:** year one most likely *loses* about \$3,300 before one-time legal costs. Break-even is about two orders a day, most likely reached around mid-2027.

1 What the business is

Play Before Pixels sells play-and-talk products for families of young children: printables, print-on-demand paperbacks and a written, email-delivered course. It is a trade name of **AlphaPlay LLC**, which is the legal seller on every account, receipt and contract.

- **Who buys:** parents of children aged 0–5 and gift-givers first. Ages 5–12, other countries' print editions and group buyers come later, each only when cleared.
- **Where it sells:** Etsy and Gumroad for downloads (worldwide), Amazon KDP for paperbacks. Free Pinterest pins and an opt-in email list bring people in. No paid ads at launch.
- **What it never does:** no coaching, calls or live events; no stock at home; no health or development claims; never names or criticizes anyone; faceless (logo and brand name only, never your face or name).
- **Who does the work:** Claude builds and runs it on a schedule. You approve, sign and own.

2 What's built, and where it lives

Everything lives in one GitHub repository, `playbeforepixels`. The working branch is `claude/live`; `main` is a copy.

WHAT	STATUS	FOLDER
18 products	Print files, previews, covers, mockups and listing text for each	<code>products/</code>

Upload packets	10 Etsy, 11 Gumroad, 1 KDP paperback, ready to paste in. 504 automatic checks, none failing	ops/UPLOAD-PACKETS/
Website	Multi-page site built, not yet online	site/
Logo and brand	The Maker's Seal kit, fonts, colors, rules	brand/
Marketing	60 Pinterest pins on 12 boards, profile images and bios, welcome emails	marketing/
Policies	Terms, privacy, refunds, disclaimer, accessibility. Drafts, waiting for an attorney	legal/
Money	Business plan, financial model, stress test, bookkeeping workbook, tax setup	business/ , finance/
Operations	The routine's instructions, approvals, deadlines, safety files	ops/

Key papers for you: ops/ACCOUNT-SETUP-CHECKLIST.pdf (your setup steps), ops/APPROVALS.md (your yes/no list), ops/LEGITIMACY-CHECK.md (the legal gate, item by item).

3 How it runs itself

Three scheduled "routines" start on their own in the cloud, even with your laptop closed. The heavy ones run overnight so they don't compete with your own daytime Claude use. All times Eastern.

DAILY STUDIO

2:47 a.m.

Monday to Saturday. Builds or improves one product, improves one page, queues posts. **Paused** until your setup steps are done.

WEEKLY RESEARCH

Sun 3:52 a.m.

Re-ranks what to build next and re-checks facts marked unverified. **Off:** you switch it on after the business environment exists.

DAILY CHECK

6:38 a.m.

Store and site health, approvals, and your money update. **Off** until the first store opens.

Each run starts fresh, reads the repository, does its work, saves it to `claude/live`, and ends with your money report.

The PAUSE file. While `ops/PAUSE` exists, the routines research and build but publish, post, list, send and upload **nothing**. Claude deletes it only when all seven Gate A items hold (your lawyer's written yes, bank, insurance bound, money cap set, safeguards live, accounts and keys ready, policies reviewed) and you type "go". Anyone can re-create it at any time to stop publishing at once.

What you will see

Yesterday: \$X in sales · This month so far: \$Y · Profit this month (est.): \$Z. Nothing needs you.

Weekly: earnings, profit, top three products, tax set aside. Monthly: revenue, profit, change on last month, and the one change that would earn most next month. **Your only alarm:** if no money line arrives by breakfast, open `claude.ai/code/routines`. Keep usage credits **off** (`claude.ai/settings/usage`) so the routines can never add metered charges.

4 Your one-time steps, in order

About 4½ hours in all. The details for each account are in `ops/ACCOUNT-SETUP-CHECKLIST.pdf`; the cloud settings are in `ops/CLOUD-RUNBOOK.md` ("one-time setup"). Everything goes in AlphaPlay LLC's name with its EIN, never your Social Security number.

1	TODAY · URGENT	5 min
	Confirm the Claude GitHub App can see the repository, then make the repository private and set its default branch to <code>claude/live</code> (runbook steps 1–3).	
2	TODAY	20 min
	Send your lawyer the question packet and ask for a written yes or no by Fri Oct 16 . That answer sets launch day.	
3	SEP 29	30 min
	Open a no-fee business checking account with a tax savings sub-account (checklist §1).	
4	SEP 30	35 min
	Ask 2–3 brokers for written insurance quotes: general liability with products cover. Bind the lowest on the day your lawyer says yes.	
5	OCT 1–2	75 min
	Buy the domain and set up business email, rent a USPS PO Box, file the \$25 trade name, check the LLC's good standing, add retail and digital sales to its Maryland sales-tax registration (checklist §2–3).	
6	BY OCT 4	10 min
	Launch spending is capped at \$500 (decided). Write down a review date and the most household money the business may use after launch, before sales cover its costs (the old placeholder was \$12,000).	
7	OCT 5–9	75 min
	One account sitting: Etsy (shop on vacation), KDP (save the draft, order one proof to the PO Box), Gumroad, Pinterest, the email platform, one capped virtual card, and the keys into the cloud settings (checklist §4–8).	
8	SAME WEEK	20 min
	Create the "Play Before Pixels" cloud environment and point the routines at it, with no connectors (runbook steps 4–7).	
9	BEFORE LAUNCH	—
	An attorney reviews the policy pages.	
10	LAUNCH DAY (TARGET OCT 16)	1 min
	Type "go" in a Claude session.	
11	WHEN THE PROOF ARRIVES	15 min
	Check the cover and page 1, then click Publish on KDP (once the website is live).	

Deadlines off the sales path that cannot slip

- **Before Nov 11, 2026:** copyright filings (fees likely rise after). They need your own human-written edits first. Their fees (about \$45–\$85 each, unverified) are *not* in the \$500 list: pay them from the buffer only if you choose.
- **As soon as possible:** the free USPTO change-of-address form for ALPHAPLAY, so notices reach you.
- **Mar 8, 2027:** ALPHAPLAY Statement of Use or extension, or the trademark is lost. Claude prepares the packet by Feb 1.
- **Apr 15, 2027:** Maryland annual report (\$300).

5 Every open decision

Each takes a few minutes. Reply in `ops/APPROVALS.md` or in a session. **Red** is the recommendation.

DECISION	RECOMMENDATION	DETAILS
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Make the repository private	Do it today	ops/APPROVALS.md
Routine-card search words "first then board", "visual schedule" (D9)	REPLACE	ops/APPROVALS.md
How research-page sign-ups are emailed (D10)	A: no product email unless they tick a box	ops/APPROVALS.md
Founder story, public version	Approve the SITE-SAFE CUT, after your lawyer reviews	content/founder-story.md
Paid reviewers for the research pages (\$4,900 cap)	Wait: deferred by the \$500 budget; the research pages stay unpublished	ops/APPROVALS.md
How much the brand says about "virtual autism" in year one	Explain once, then stop	marketing/BRAND-RESPECT-PLAN.md \$4
Course refund window	Keep 14 days (everything already matches)	legal/SHIPPING-RETURNS-REFUNDS.md
KDP prices in the UK, Canada, Australia	£13.99 · CA\$22.99 · AU\$26.99	ops/UPLOAD-PACKETS/README.md
"Preschoolers" on the paperback subtitle and cover	Keep (an age word)	same
Name "Birth-to-5 Printable Library" (Gumroad only)	Keep	same
Routine-card price (D1) · smallest price (D2) · Etsy Offsite Ads (D3)	\$9.50 · \$5.00 · Off	business/GROWTH-ENGINE.md
Own checkout (D4) · Black Friday (D5) · Play Club (D6)	Gumroad for now · a dated free bonus · wait	same
Only changed pages need a proof for a new edition (D7)	Yes, saves 2–4 hours	same
Review date and post-launch money cap (launch is capped at \$500)	Set both	step 6
Logo: the Maker's Seal is adopted; your own dated edits are optional	Optional: a small edit of your own makes the drawing more clearly yours	brand/logo/logo-notes.md
If no ALPHAPLAY sales by Feb 1, 2027	Attorney files an extension	ops/DEADLINES.md
Legal and tax items from the legitimacy check	See the PENDING lines	ops/LEGITIMACY-CHECK.md

Already decided (September 28, business/DECISIONS.md): the logo is the Maker's Seal only · KDP books use Amazon's free ISBN · the *30 Days of Back-and-Forth* course stays, fully self-running, and needs nothing from you · launch spending is capped at \$500 with no ads.

6 What Claude does from here

Before launch day

- **Done:** listing fixes, compliance-gate records for every launch item, the Gate A file, and the legitimacy-check drafts (corporate records, insurance record, testimonial log).

After you say "go"

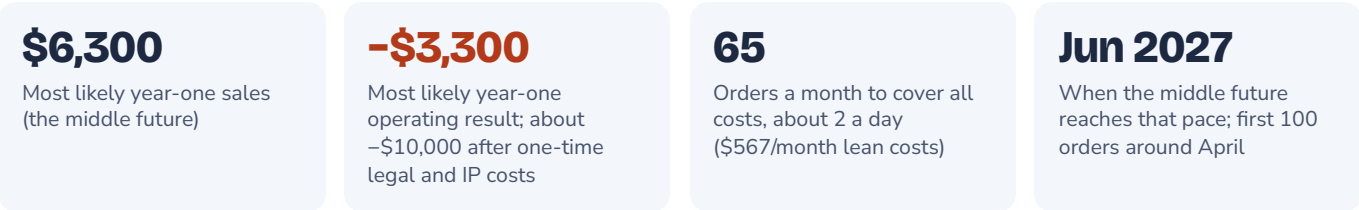
- List up to 5 Etsy products a week, and paperbacks as proofs pass.
- Pin 3–5 times a day; send approved emails to people who opted in.

- Get the website ready to go live before the paperback, which prints its address.
- Small fixes that don't block launch: merch "next" links, course emails that mention the paperback, busy-book bonus piece sizes, and the back cover of *Whose Lap Today?* (it lists two held books).
- Check every live listing, answer routine buyer questions with saved replies.
- Monthly books close, tax reserve, and deadlines prepared 30 days early.
- Make more of what sells; fold what doesn't.

What Claude never does without your written APPROVED line: spend money, email or message a person, post in a group, add a platform, or change terms. It never contacts anyone by phone or in person, and never writes about you, your family or your work.

7 The money picture, honestly

From `business/STRESS-TEST.md` : 10,000 simulated futures for October 2026 to September 2027, with no ad budget. These are planning estimates, not a promise.



- **The range is wide.** One future in ten sells more than \$19,800 and earns more than \$6,300. One in ten sells under \$2,000. The plan's "Expected" year (\$11,195) happens in about one future in four.
- **2026 is a setup year.** Most likely under \$100 of sales. \$1,000,000 by December is not realistic (it would take about 1,400 orders a day).
- **Each sale keeps most of its price:** 80–93% of a printable on Etsy, about \$3–\$8 per paperback, about \$24.57 of the \$27 course.
- **Money you may need to put in:** the stress test (run before the \$500 decision) put the deepest point at about \$7,600 if costs stay at the lowest quotes and about \$11,300 if they drift up. The \$500 plan spends far less at launch by skipping ads, paid reviewers, extra domains and Shopify, but monthly costs such as insurance and the PO Box continue after it.
- **What helps most:** holding every cost to the lowest written quote (+\$2,000), trimming about \$100 a month of fixed costs (+\$1,200), more traffic and better listings (+\$900 each), and selling by November 1 (+\$800).
- **What hurts:** \$150 a month of ads lowers median profit by about \$684. The insurance quote is the one number most likely to move break-even (at a mid-range price, 84 orders a month instead of 65).

8 How you are protected

The one gap today: the repository is public, so anyone can read the plans and notes. Step 1 fixes it. Then ask your lawyer whether anything already seen needs more than that.

PROTECTION	HOW IT WORKS
The LLC is the seller	Every account, contract and payout is AlphaPlay LLC's, under its EIN. Keep business money in the business account only; that keeps the LLC's shield strong.

Your address stays private	Only the USPS PO Box ever appears in public. Your home address goes only on the few government filings that require a street address.
Faceless brand	No photo, name or personal story on any profile. The founder story stays anonymous and needs your lawyer's review first.
Nothing risky is said or sold	No health claims, no naming anyone, one honest price per product, AI use disclosed. Every public item passes a 22-line compliance gate first.
Your lawyer goes first	Nothing is sold or marketed until your lawyer's written yes.
Insurance before the first sale	General liability with products cover, bound before launch, naming both the LLC and you.
Your personal accounts stay out	Personal Gmail, Drive and Calendar are never connected to the routines. Keys live only in the cloud settings, never in chat or the repository.
Spending is capped	One virtual card with a monthly limit, a household money cap, and no purchase without your APPROVED line.
Deadlines are watched	Trademark, copyright, tax and renewal dates are prepared 30 days ahead and reach you as one line.

9 The emergency stops

IF YOU WANT TO...	DO THIS
Stop all publishing now	Create a file named <code>ops/PAUSE</code> (on GitHub: <i>Add file</i> → <i>Create new file</i> , any text, on <code>claude/live</code>). Or tell any Claude session "pause". Every run checks it right before publishing.
Stop the routines completely	<code>claude.ai/code/routines</code> → switch each routine off. A run already going finishes, so create <code>ops/PAUSE</code> too.
Cut off one platform at once	Cloud environment settings → API credentials → delete that platform's key.
Stop what PAUSE can't reach	Scheduled posts, email automations and ads keep running on the platforms themselves. Etsy: vacation mode. Email platform: pause automations. The full list is in <code>ops/FULL-STOP.md</code> .
Stop any spending	Freeze the virtual card in your bank app.
Something personal is public	Make the repository private, create <code>ops/PAUSE</code> , and tell your lawyer.

Nothing restarts until you say so. To resume, delete `ops/PAUSE` (or say "go") and switch the routines back on.



Play Before Pixels

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